Children Helped Make the Middle East's Oldest Clay Figures

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Thousands of years before anyone invented pottery, people in the Middle East were already shaping clay into tiny figures. Now archaeologists say more than 150 of these **miniature** artworks, found at sites across present-day Israel, are likely the earliest clay figures ever found in the region. And some of them were made by children.

The figures date back 11,500 to 15,000 years. They were made by the **Natufians**, a people who lived in the **Fertile Crescent** between 9,500 and 13,000 BCE. The **Natufians** were **hunter-gatherers** who were beginning to settle down and move toward farming, long before the first permanent villages appeared in the region.

The figures show animals such as birds and hooved mammals like deer, as well as male and female people. Some still carry traces of **pigment** and dyes. Others carry something even more personal: the ancient fingerprints of the artists who made them.

Those fingerprints tell a surprising story. By studying the marks left in the clay, researchers found that both children and adults took part in making the figures.

That matters because clay is not like stone or bone. Earlier Natufian figures were carved from hard materials by breaking, sanding, or whittling them into shape. Clay demanded different skills: shaping soft earth, then baking and hardening it into something that would last. As the study's authors wrote, the shift required diverse tools, skills, and knowledge.

The findings were published in the journal PLOS One. Laurent Davin, a study co-author and archaeologist at The Hebrew University of Jerusalem, said people were already using clay to create figures thousands of years before agriculture and pottery emerged, as part of their beliefs and knowledge of the natural world. What fascinates him most, he said, is the evidence that children helped make these objects, suggesting that creativity and cultural knowledge were shared across generations.

Word Treasure

miniature -- Miniature means very small, like a tiny model of something bigger.

Natufians -- The Natufians were a group of people who lived in the Middle East thousands of years ago.

Fertile Crescent -- The Fertile Crescent is a crescent-shaped area in the Middle East where early farming began.

hunter-gatherers -- Hunter-gatherers are people who find food by hunting animals and gathering wild plants.

pigment -- Pigment is a substance that gives something its color, like paint.

Background you need

Archaeologists study objects left behind by people long ago to learn how they lived, what they believed, and how they made things.

Clay is soft earth that can be shaped by hand and then baked hard, which is why people later used it to make pots and other useful objects.

The Natufians lived at a turning point in history, when people were starting to settle in one place and grow food instead of moving around to find it.

Fingerprints left in soft clay can survive for a very long time once the clay hardens, giving a direct link to the people who made an object.

Break it down

LEAD: More than 150 tiny clay figures from the Middle East are likely the region's earliest, and some were made by children.

KEY EVENT: Archaeologists link the figures to the Natufians, who lived in the Fertile Crescent long before farming.

+- WHEN: 11,500 to 15,000 years ago.

+- WHAT: Figures of birds, hooved mammals like deer, and male and female people, some with pigment and fingerprints.

+- EVIDENCE: Fingerprints in the clay show both children and adults took part in making them.

WHY IT MATTERS: Clay needed new skills -- shaping, baking, and hardening -- unlike carving stone or bone.

OPEN QUESTION: What did these figures mean to the people who made them, as part of their beliefs and knowledge of nature?

Why it matters

The figures show that creativity and shared knowledge crossed generations thousands of years before farming and pottery, and they push back the story of how people first learned to work with clay.

Test what you remember

1. How many clay figures did the archaeologists study?

- (A) Exactly 150
- (B) More than 150
- (C) About 50
- (D) More than 1,500

2. How old are the figures?

- (A) 1,150 to 1,500 years old
- (B) 115,000 to 150,000 years old
- (C) About 500 years old
- (D) 11,500 to 15,000 years old

3. Who made the figures?

- (A) Roman artists
- (B) Medieval monks
- (C) The first potters of Egypt
- (D) The Natufians

4. What surprising evidence did the fingerprints give?

- (A) The figures were made by machines
- (B) The figures were painted by one artist
- (C) Both children and adults helped make the figures
- (D) Only kings were allowed to make them

5. How were earlier Natufian figures made?

- (A) Cast in metal
- (B) Printed with a press
- (C) Woven from grass
- (D) Carved from hard materials like stone or bone

6. Where were the findings published?

- (A) In a book about pottery
- (B) On a museum website
- (C) In the journal PLOS One
- (D) In a children's magazine

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: D 4: C 5: D 6: C

Questions to think about

1. The study's authors: They write that moving to clay required diverse tools, skills, and knowledge.

2. Laurent Davin: He says people were already using clay to make figures thousands of years before agriculture and pottery emerged, as part of their beliefs and knowledge of the natural world, and finds the children's fingerprints the most fascinating part.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):